

DEHYDRATING AND SMOKING

Teens (14–18)

Q

Why is removing moisture from foods important for drying and storing them safely?

DEHYDRATING AND SMOKING

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ANSWER

It prevents microorganisms from growing and spoiling the food

FUN FACT

Drying is the oldest food preservation method, used since ancient times!

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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Q

At what temperature should you keep fruit leather in a dehydrator to dry it safely and properly?

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ANSWER

Around 140°F

FUN FACT

Fruit leather should be dry with no sticky spots before you take it out!

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

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How long should you heat dried jerky in a 275°F oven after drying to ensure it's safe?

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ANSWER

10 minutes

FUN FACT

This extra heating step kills harmful germs that drying alone might not destroy.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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Q

Why is it important to brine fish in a salt solution before smoking?

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Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Salt helps preserve the fish and adds flavor while preventing spoilage

FUN FACT

A fish brined well will have a shiny, sticky surface called a pellicle for better smoke adhesion!

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What moisture condition should dried fruits and vegetables have to store them safely?

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ANSWER

They must be dry enough to prevent any microbial growth

FUN FACT

Very dry dried foods can last many months if stored cool and dark!

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

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Why can traditional jerky drying methods using about 140°-155°F be unsafe if used alone?

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ANSWER

They may not kill pathogens hidden inside the meat

FUN FACT

Ground meat jerky is especially risky without extra heating steps because germs spread inside it.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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What does the pellicle on fish before smoking help to do?

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ANSWER

It helps the smoke stick and prevents surface spoilage

FUN FACT

If you can't dry fish in cool air, use low heat with open doors to form the pellicle in the smoker.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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How many ounces of jerky can be made from 16 ounces of raw meat?

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ANSWER

About 4 ounces

FUN FACT

Jerky is lightweight because drying removes most of the water.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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Why is curing salt used in smoking meats like bacon?

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ANSWER

To preserve the meat and prevent bacteria growth

FUN FACT

Curing salt is also called Prague Powder and is critical for safe smoked bacon.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home

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What is the recommended way to arrange dried jerky strips on a baking sheet for post-drying heating?

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ANSWER

Close together but not touching or overlapping

FUN FACT

This arrangement ensures even heating and safety.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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Why should fruit leather be stored in a cool, dark, and dry place?

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ANSWER

To slow down spoilage and maintain quality

FUN FACT

You can freeze fruit leather for up to a year to keep it fresh!

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

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What is a good brine ratio for salting fish before smoking?

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ANSWER

1 part table salt to 7 parts water by volume

FUN FACT

This brine makes a 60° SAL solution to properly salt fish.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What is the main reason jerky should be conditioned after drying and heating?

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ANSWER

To equalize moisture and avoid mold during storage

FUN FACT

Conditioning usually means storing jerky in a loosely closed container for a few days.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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What kind of salt is recommended for curing fish before smoking?

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ANSWER

Non-iodized salt with no anticaking agents

FUN FACT

Non-iodized salt prevents unwanted flavors and discoloration in smoked fish.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What is the scientific reason drying preserves food safely?

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ANSWER

Removing moisture prevents growth of microbes that cause spoilage

FUN FACT

Without water, bacteria and molds can't grow well on food.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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In traditional jerky making, why is heating or precooking the meat recommended?

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ANSWER

To kill pathogens prior to drying

FUN FACT

Drying alone at low temps can leave dangerous bacteria alive.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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How should fish pieces be arranged when brining for smoking?

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ANSWER

Not overlapping to allow even salt penetration

FUN FACT

Overlapping can cause uneven salting and spoilage risks.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

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What happens if cured pork belly is under-rinsed after curing?

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ANSWER

The final meat product will be too salty

FUN FACT

Rinsing removes surface salt but not curing salt inside the meat.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home

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Why should jerky be dried at the right steady temperature, usually about 140°F?

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ANSWER

To dry meat safely without cooking it

FUN FACT

Proper drying temperature balances drying time and safety.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

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What is a common safety concern when making jerky from ground meat?

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ANSWER

Pathogens can be spread inside the meat, making it harder to kill

FUN FACT

That's why extra heating steps are important for ground meat jerky.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely